

AWS SAA-C03 Study Tracker

Based on the official AWS Exam Guide + your 12–13 week / 2 hrs-per-day plan

Domain Weightings (from official exam guide)

Domain	Weight	Your focus weeks
1. Design Secure Architectures	30%	Weeks 1–2, 7
2. Design Resilient Architectures	26%	Weeks 3–4
3. Design High-Performing Architectures	24%	Weeks 3–6
4. Design Cost-Optimized Architectures	20%	Week 8

Domain 1 (Security) carries the most weight — don't undercook IAM, KMS, and network security even though it feels "basic."

Weeks 1–2 — Domain 1: Secure Architectures (30%)

Task 1.1 — Secure access to AWS resources

- ☐ IAM users, groups, roles, policies (identity-based vs resource-based)
- ☐ MFA best practices for root + IAM users
- ☐ AWS STS, role switching, cross-account access
- ☐ AWS IAM Identity Center (federated access)
- ☐ Multi-account strategy: AWS Organizations, Control Tower, SCPs
- ☐ Shared responsibility model

Task 1.2 — Secure workloads and applications

- ☐ VPC security: security groups vs NACLs, route tables, NAT gateways
- ☐ Public vs private subnet segmentation
- ☐ AWS Shield, AWS WAF (DDoS/SQLi threat vectors)
- ☐ Amazon Cognito, GuardDuty, Macie — use cases
- ☐ AWS Secrets Manager for app credentials
- ☐ VPN / AWS Direct Connect for external connections

Task 1.3 — Data security controls

- ☐ Encryption at rest (AWS KMS) and in transit (ACM/TLS)
 - ☐ Key rotation, certificate renewal
 - ☐ Data backup/replication strategies
 - ☐ Access policies for encryption keys, data classification
-

Weeks 3–4 — Domain 2: Resilient Architectures (26%)

Task 2.1 — Scalable, loosely coupled architectures

- ☐ SQS, SNS, EventBridge (pub/sub, decoupling)
- ☐ API Gateway + REST APIs
- ☐ Microservices: stateless vs stateful
- ☐ Horizontal vs vertical scaling
- ☐ CDN / edge accelerators (CloudFront)
- ☐ Load balancing (ALB) concepts
- ☐ Multi-tier architecture design
- ☐ Containers: ECS, EKS — when to use
- ☐ Serverless: Lambda, Fargate
- ☐ Storage types: object / file / block
- ☐ RDS read replicas — when to use
- ☐ Step Functions (workflow orchestration)

Task 2.2 — Highly available / fault-tolerant architectures

- ☐ Multi-AZ / multi-Region design
 - ☐ DR strategies: backup & restore, pilot light, warm standby, active-active + RPO/RTO
 - ☐ Failover strategies, immutable infrastructure
 - ☐ RDS Proxy
 - ☐ Service quotas & throttling
 - ☐ Storage durability & replication options
 - ☐ AWS X-Ray for visibility
-

Weeks 5–6 — Domain 3: High-Performing Architectures (24%) — Part 1

Task 3.1 — Storage performance/scale

- ☐ S3, EFS, EBS — performance characteristics

- ☐ Hybrid storage for performance needs

Task 3.2 — Compute performance/elasticity

- ☐ EC2 instance families & sizing
- ☐ Auto Scaling (EC2 ASG, AWS Auto Scaling)
- ☐ AWS Batch, EMR, Fargate use cases
- ☐ Container orchestration (ECS/EKS)
- ☐ Lambda memory/resource sizing

Task 3.3 — Database performance

- ☐ ElastiCache caching strategies
- ☐ Read-heavy vs write-heavy access patterns
- ☐ DB capacity planning (IOPS, capacity units)
- ☐ Aurora vs DynamoDB vs RDS — when to use which
- ☐ Read replicas for performance

Week 7 — Domain 3 Part 2 + Domain 1 wrap-up

Task 3.4 — Network performance

- ☐ CloudFront, Global Accelerator
- ☐ Subnet tiers, routing, IP addressing design
- ☐ Direct Connect vs VPN vs PrivateLink
- ☐ Load balancer type selection

Task 3.5 — Data ingestion/transformation

- ☐ Kinesis (streaming data)
- ☐ AWS Glue (transformation), Lake Formation, Athena
- ☐ DataSync, Storage Gateway (data transfer)
- ☐ Format transformation (e.g., CSV → Parquet)

Domain 1 gap-fill

- ☐ Re-review anything shaky from weeks 1–2 (this domain is 30% — worth a second pass)

Week 8 — Domain 4: Cost-Optimized Architectures (20%)

Task 4.1 — Storage cost

- ☐ S3 storage classes & lifecycle policies
- ☐ EBS volume types (cost vs performance)
- ☐ Cost tools: Cost Explorer, Budgets, Cost and Usage Report

Task 4.2 — Compute cost

- ☐ Purchasing options: On-Demand, Reserved, Spot, Savings Plans
- ☐ Instance right-sizing
- ☐ EC2 hibernation, scaling for cost

Task 4.3 — Database cost

- ☐ DynamoDB vs RDS cost tradeoffs
- ☐ Backup/retention policy design for cost

Task 4.4 — Network cost

- ☐ NAT gateway vs NAT instance cost
- ☐ Data transfer cost minimization (VPC endpoints, Region/AZ routing)
- ☐ Direct Connect vs VPN cost tradeoffs

Also this week:

- ☐ Read the AWS Well-Architected Framework whitepaper (6 pillars) — ties all 4 domains together

Weeks 9–11 — Practice Test Phase

- ☐ Full timed practice test (alternate days)
- ☐ Log score + weak domains below
- ☐ Deep-review every wrong answer (the "why," not just the right choice)

Attempt #	Date	Score	Weakest domain
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

Weeks 12–13 — Final Polish

- ☐ Consistently scoring 85%+ on practice exams
 - ☐ Light review only — no new content
 - ☐ Book exam date
-

Full In-Scope Service Checklist (quick self-audit)

Use this as a gut-check near the end — for each service, ask "could I say in one sentence when to use this vs its main alternative?"

Compute/Containers: EC2, EC2 Auto Scaling, Elastic Beanstalk, Outposts, Batch, ECS, ECR, EKS, Fargate, Lambda

Storage: S3, S3 Glacier, EBS, EFS, FSx, Storage Gateway, Backup

Database: RDS, Aurora, Aurora Serverless, DynamoDB, ElastiCache, DocumentDB, Neptune, Keyspaces, Redshift

Networking: VPC, Route 53, CloudFront, ELB, Global Accelerator, Direct Connect, Site-to-Site VPN, Client VPN, Transit Gateway, PrivateLink

Security: IAM, IAM Identity Center, KMS, Secrets Manager, ACM, Cognito, GuardDuty, Macie, Shield, WAF, Network Firewall, Security Hub, Detective, CloudHSM, Artifact, Audit Manager, RAM

App Integration: SQS, SNS, EventBridge, Step Functions, AppSync, Amazon MQ, AppFlow

Analytics: Athena, Kinesis (+ Data Firehose), EMR, Glue, Lake Formation, OpenSearch, MSK, Redshift, QuickSuite, Data Exchange

Management/Governance: CloudFormation, CloudWatch, CloudTrail, Config, Systems Manager, Organizations, Control Tower, Trusted Advisor, Well-Architected Tool, Compute Optimizer, Service Catalog, License Manager, Managed Grafana/Prometheus

Migration: Application Migration Service, DMS, DataSync, Snow Family, Transfer Family

Cost Management: Budgets, Cost Explorer, Cost and Usage Report, Savings Plans

Front-end/Serverless extras: API Gateway, Amplify, Device Farm

ML (light conceptual knowledge only): SageMaker AI, Rekognition, Comprehend, Textract, Translate, Transcribe, Polly, Lex, Kendra

Tip: check the "Out-of-Scope AWS Services" page of the exam guide too — knowing what you DON'T need to study saves time